Who is Luigi Conti Vecchi (1850 - 1927)
A visionary Tuscan engineer and entrepreneur who founded the **Saline Conti Vecchi** in Sardinia. He is remembered as an "enlightened" industrialist for transforming a disease-ridden swamp into one of Europe's most productive saltworks while simultaneously creating a model social community.

- Before saltworks, he was railway director, general during WWI, infrastructure expert building prominent bridges & aqueducts & railway line in Italy
- In 1919, he presented his plan to Cagliari City Council to reclaim 2,700 hectares of the Santa Gilla lagoon to
  - eradicate malaria as the lagoon was a malarial swamp.
  - modified the banks, drain the stagnant water by replacing with circulating system of seawater for salt production
  - Built factory
  - Built **Porto San Pietro, 2 km from the salt mine, used to transport salt by sea to the Port of Cagliari** .
  - created self-sufficient industrial hub that produced salt (white gold)
  - Built a salt village "Macchiareddu", where workers & managers lived together with access to free schools, a church, a pharmacy, and recreational facilities.
  - It was built and managed to improve the lives of those who worked and, consequently, lived there: from houses with gardens and ensuite bathrooms, to services such as an infirmary, canteen, and shop, to recreational activities organized after work.
  - In addition to excellent salaries for the time, **at the Conti Vecchi Saltworks, constant training was provided to employees** . For example, women were trained to work as analysts in the chemical laboratory. A meritocratic career was encouraged, and even the children of workers born in the village could hold management roles
  - **the right to education was guaranteed for children** . They were not employed as manual laborers, but went to school within the village, where there was a nursery and elementary school, which the Conti Vecchi children also attended.
  - **Production began in 1931 with the first harvest of salt for sale** , a harvest that at the time was entirely done by hand. **The company grew to employ 350 people** during the salt-growing seasons and more than 1,000 during the harvest season. Furthermore, the company was completely self-sufficient; within the saltworks, it had a workshop and a carpentry shop that independently produced all the spare parts needed for saltworks maintenance, based on designs from the technical office.

Guido Conti Vecchi took over management after Luigi passed away. He carried on this salt mine

1930s, produced about 250,000 tonnes

- **Labor Force:** About 500 permanent workers lived in the onsite village of Macchiareddu, but this number rose to over **1,000–1,500 seasonal workers** during the harvest season.

- **Production Method:** Seasonal workers, described as "sun-scorched" and "blinded," worked from September to November (sometimes until Christmas) using pickaxes and traditional tools to detach the salt from the bottom of the basins.

not only produced salt but also magnesium, plaster, and potassium

During WW2, after the heavy bombings of Cagliari in 1940, the salt mine remained unproductive for two years , and in 1944 and 1945 no salt was harvested.

In the 1960s, with the introduction of technological advances and a change of ownership, the employment of labourers decreased drastically and the village was gradually abandoned.

In the 1980s , following two serious industrial crises that affected Sardinia, and after complication, the salt pans were acquired by Eni, partly state-owned

Over the decades, the salt pan passed from Conti Vecchi's grandchildren to Rovelli's SNE, and in 1986 to the Italian state, which later entrusted it to ENI.

In 2018 - Implemented 26 MWp photovoltaic plant at the Saline Conti Vecchi.

Part of Progetto Italia, a series of Eni initiatives to add sustainable value.

Collaboration between Eni and GSE, focusing on circular economy, reducing CO2.
Produce 42 GWh/year
Energy produced will power the salt production cycle, covering 70% of total energy consumption.

- Assemini hub for renewable energy technologies - lab for environmental/energy tech development
- revitalize Syndial industrial area, already under remediation
-

Who is GSE?
(Gestore dei Servizi Energetici) - State-owned Italian company under the Ministry of Economy & Finance that drives transition to sustainable energy. Promotes renewable energy, energy efficiency, manages over 15bil euros in annual incentives and certify green energy production

WHo is Eni?
(Ente Nazionale Idrocarburi) is an Italian multinational "Supermajor" energy company founded in 1953.
oil and natural gas exploration, production, refining, renewable energy, and chemical production, heavily investing in decarbonization and sustainable energy solutions.

- Partially state-owned approx 33% stake through Ministry of Economy & Finance

OWNER of both Syndial (Eni Rewind) and company Ing. Luigi Conti Vecchi S.p.A.

The Corporate Structure:

- **Eni S.p.A.:** The ultimate parent company.

- **Eni Rewind (formerly Syndial):** A wholly-owned subsidiary of Eni that specializes in environmental remediation and managing industrial sites.

- **Ing. Luigi Conti Vecchi S.p.A.:** This is the specific company that operates the saltworks. It is **controlled by Eni Rewind**.

ENI "inherited" the saltworks through a complex history of Italian industrial shifts:

- **1984 Acquisition:** The Italian state forced Eni to take over the site during a period of ***industrial crisis*** for the previous owners (SIR-Rumianca).
- **Dual Operation:** Today, the site functions in two ways:
  a. **Industrial:** Eni Rewind (via the company *Ing. Luigi Conti Vecchi S.p.A.*) continues to produce salt for industrial and food use.
  b. **Cultural/Tourist:** FAI manages the "museum" areas and public tours to show off the historical and natural beauty.

ENI & FAI partnership 10 years - started in 2016: redevelop & upgrade the area

Who is FAI (Fondo Ambiente Italiano)
National Trust for Italy - prominent non-profit foundation established in 1975, protecting, restoring, managing Italy's artistic, cultural, and landscape heritage. Preserves over 70 sites.
safeguard landscape and artistic heritage for future generation.

For Saline Conti Vecchi specifically

Industrial archaeology

- restored buildings to 1930s appearance
  - offices, laboratories to look like original period
  - multimedia storytelling - old carpenter's workshop to tell the story of the salt community that lived there.

Environmental

- as part of Santa Gilla lagoon, a protected wetland:
  - wildlife protection: managing as sanctuary for over 50 bird species
  - Built sustainable infrastructure: In 2025, implemented sound-absorbing pavement for cars to minimize noise for nesting birds; build 3km luminescent cycle path (longest in Europe) that glows at night without needing artificial lights.

Visitor Experience

- making site accessible with guided train tours - open-air train through the salt pans and white mountains of salt while learning about ecosystem & industrial process
- hosting educational workshops for kids and adults with art, science, & environ programs
- Hosting special events with sunset aperitif & live music
- offers visitors the opportunity to explore a unique landscape where nature and industrial history intertwine to create a truly fascinating experience.

ESSENTIALLY OPERATES SALINE CONTI VECCHI's TOURISM

Since 2017, the Saline Conti Vecchi in Cagliari have been one of two FAI (Italian Environment Fund) properties **in Sardinia** , along with the Talmone Military Battery in Palau, and are unique in their kind because they are the only FAI property within a production site.

The FAI continues to preserve the memory of that community by keeping alive a salt museum, a chemical laboratory, and a mechanical workshop, all of which offer a fascinating lens through which to explore the field of industrial archaeology.

"cultivation" of culture has been entrusted to the FAI through "experiencial" activities at the industrial archaeology site and in the naturalistic area. "Until 2017, only salt workers were allowed to enter the area with the ancient industrial structures," explains **Francesca Caldara** , head of the operational management of the FAI Saline Conti Vecchi museum site. "We wanted **to give back to the area and the local community a little-known piece of their history** and that of engineer Luigi Conti Vecchi.

Management Building: the main offices on the first floor, the workshop where the salt-harvesting machines were repaired on the ground floor, the former carpentry shop, and the chemical laboratory . The rooms and furnishings are in 1920s style, dating back to the time the saltworks was founded. And there are **plans to restore the houses in the workers' village** .

2022 - Eni sold the industrial operation to **Italkali**

In 2022, the saltworks became part of the Italkali group , a leading company in the production and marketing of national rock salt, known for the Sale di Sicilia brand, the "best-selling iodized salt in Italy": the "salt with the diamond" in its logo. The **Saline Conti Vecchi line, on the other hand, includes the white gold extracted from the sea in a wide range of grain sizes and uses** , both for food and livestock use, including fleur de sel, which is "cultivated" under specific wind and sun exposure conditions, surfacing on the surface of the salt pans, and for industry and thawing **.**

Italkali – Società Italiana Sali Alcalini SpA – has been active on the market for over 40 years and has acquired the role of main player on the national market and important positions on the European market. The Sale di Sicilia brand is the best-selling iodized salt in Italy. Production takes place at multiple mining sites

production capacity of 400,000 tons, the company produces 150,000 tons of salt for food and livestock use, and 250,000 tons for industrial and de-icing applications.
production process designed to yield a product of exceptional purity.

bituminous mix in pavement

use of Iteroxid GR HP yellow technology; counteracting heat island too. photoluminescent aggregates used on surface layer to aborb sunlight during daytime, generating luminescent effect at night time.

CONTESTATIONS

While FAI's restoration of **Saline Conti Vecchi** is widely praised as a model of "industrial archaeology", it has faced specific criticisms and "contestations" rooted in its partnership with the energy giant **Eni** and broader local socio-political concerns.

Greenwashing Debate
The most significant criticism involves FAI's strategic partnership with **Eni** (specifically its subsidiary, Syndial/Eni Rewind), which owns the site.

Whose history is told. Is the narrative focused on the visionary "great men" (the Conti Vecchi family) or the harsh, often exploitative conditions of the historical salt workers?

The Salt Shield: How does the 'green' infrastructure of Saline Conti Vecchi mediate the politics of shoreline ownership, allowing industrial giants to negotiate climate pressure while divesting from environmental accountability?

Selling of the industrial operation
In just over a year, between the springs of 2021 and 2022, Eni's "exit" from the management of the basic chemicals and salt pans of Macchiareddu,

https://www.unionesarda.it/news-sardegna/provincia-cagliari/eni-prepara-la-grande-fuga-dalle-saline-sarde-r9adjd6

https://www.lidentita.it/le-saline-di-cagliari-e-la-strana-fuga-dellenis/

https://www.contivecchi.com/chi-siamo

In 2022, Conti Vecchi joined the **Italkali group** , with the aim of maximizing the value of a high-quality natural sea salt, an ideal partner for the **Italian agri-food supply chain**

The "Italkali Shift"
Since the 2022 handover, Italkali has focused on **"High-Tech Purity."** They have integrated the Conti Vecchi salt into their global logistical chain. While Eni used the salt primarily as a local raw material for their chemical industrial complex, Italkali treats it as a **specialized commodity** to be exported.

The Contestation: By focusing on "purity" and "efficiency," Italkali is moving the site further away from a "community-led heritage site" and closer to a "specialized production hub"—all while the FAI (the heritage fund) continues to sell the 1930s romanticized version to tourists.

- **The 2022 Technical Handover:** When Italkali acquired the site from Eni, they took over an industrial infrastructure integrated with the **Assemini chemical complex**. This complex includes massive pumping stations that regulate the lagoon's salinity. Without electric pumps, the water would stagnate, the salinity gradient would fail, and the "sustainable" flamingo habitat would dry up.
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- **Energy Consumption Data:** Industrial salt works of this size typically rank among the largest local electricity consumers due to the continuous operation of brine-transfer pumps that run 24/7 during the evaporation season.

2. The Evidence for Diesel-Heavy Harvesting
The transition from "artisanal" to "industrial" is most visible during the **raccolta** (harvest).

- **Mechanical Scrapers vs. Hand Tools:** Italkali's production model relies on "Mechanical Harvesting." Instead of workers with shovels, the site uses heavy-duty **mechanical salt harvesters** (essentially specialized tractors with scraping blades) and a fleet of **trucks** to transport raw salt to the washing plant.
- **The Washing & Refining Plant:** Once harvested, the salt is processed in a facility that uses mechanical conveyors, centrifuges, and industrial dryers. These systems are powered by a mix of grid electricity and onsite industrial fuel.

3. The Industrial Paradox
The most compelling "proof" lies in the production numbers:

- **400,000 tonnes per year:** It is physically impossible to harvest, wash, and transport nearly half a million tonnes of material using "traditional" or purely "natural" methods.
- **The Product Split:** Italkali openly states that **250,000 tonnes** (the majority) are destined for **industrial use and de-icing**. This "market logic" requires a high-speed, low-cost extraction method that only heavy diesel machinery and high-output electric infrastructure can provide.

THE OASIS	THE FACTORY	
Heritage Vision	Industrial Reality	
Visual: Left Side (Matte Frame)	**Visual: Right Side (Daylight Operations)**	**Audio/Text Overlay**
TRADITION	**EXTRACTION**	
Archival footage (Photos) in 1920s hats with wooden shovels.	Modern footage (Gian Franco Rocca) of scrapers being fed the salt crust.	Sound: Soft wind vs. heavy engine rumble.
ECOSYSTEM	**INFRASTRUCTURE**	
Silhouette Pink Flamingos roosting in shallow, clear brine.	Wide shot: 2,700 hectares of geometric, sulphurous magenta/orange ponds.	Sound: Birdsong vs. The hum of an electric substation.
STEWARDSHIP	**DIVESTMENT**	
The FAI logo on a restored 19th-century building.	An "Italkali" sign being beaten/ overlaid by logo.	Sound: A soft mournful violin gently fades into a heavy metal or industrial beat.
THE Image	**THE Asset**	
Heritage Vision	Industrial Reality	

Narrative
Saline Conti Vecchi represents an example of sustainability and enhancement of historical heritage. After a careful restoration, this site was opened to public as a museum and a protected natural area, in collaboration with FAI

"a unique cultural promotion experience, combining industrial activity with the historical and naturalistic value of an operational site"
Today, in the presence of the Undersecretary for Cultural Heritage and Activities and Tourism, Dorina Bianchi; the President of the Sardinia Region, Francesco Pigliaru; the CEO of Eni, Claudio Descalzi; the President of the FAI, Andrea Carandini; and the CEO of Syndial, Vincenzo Maria Larocca, the ceremony was held to open to the public

Conti Vecchi saltworks in Sardinia, a model of nature and production combined in perfect harmony

- However, how is it sustainable? How are the industry giants like Eni and Italkali stewarding sustainability on site?
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Heritage: whose story does it tell? Glorifying the creator of the village. Luigi Conti Vecchi had the "foresight" to design this, build this, to share it...

- show the restored museum, the offices, the beautiful part
- the story of Conti Vecchi gets retold again and again

But what about their narrative? What about the stories of the people living here in these houses?
https://www.vistanet.it/cagliari/2018/06/23/lo-sapevate-a-macchiareddu-esiste-un-villaggio-completamente-autosufficiente-per-i-dipendenti-della-saline/

https://www.sardegnaambiente.it/villaggio-conti-vecchi/

Nature: the beautiful colors at the salt mine, the flamingos

It shows that the "Green" and the "Industrial" are not two different times (past vs. present), but **two different layers of infrastructure** operating at the same time on the same shoreline.

placing two conflicting truths side-by-side, we synthesize "third truth" - corporate negotiation